DOWNLOADS in million

5



CANDY CRUSH SAGA
by King

1,000

10



GENSHIN IMPACT
by Cognosphere Pte. Ltd.

10

Source: AppBrain



"THE INCLUSION OF ESPORTS IN THE ASIAN GAMES ADDS A LOT OF LEGITIMACY TO THIS SEGMENT"

ANEESH ARAVIND
Country Manager India, Krafton

has become the world's third-largest gaming company by revenue, behind China's Tencent and Japan's Sony. Activision's Candy Crush Saga and Call of Duty: Season 1 are among India's top 10 highest-grossing Android games. In July, Swedish gaming company Modern Times Group acquired Bengaluru-based word games developer PlaySimple for $360 million (Rs 2,720 crore).

The surging interest in online gaming is driving investors' interest in the segment. A report by investment banking platform Maple Capital Advisors said that gaming start-ups in India have attracted $1.6 billion (Rs 12,000 crore) in 43 deals between January and September 2021. Around 90 per cent of the investments went to two large players in the fantasy sports and platform gaming sector, with Dream Sports and the Mobile Premier League raising $785 million (Rs 5,917.5 crore) and $375 million (Rs 2,826.8 crore), respectively. Dream Sports announced an additional $840 million (Rs 6,332 crore) funding round on November 24. Media reports say top venture firms Accel and Matrix Partners India have invested millions of dollars in firms like PlayShifu, Zupee and Winzo.

The rising interest in games has also led to gaming tournaments being organised in India. The India Today Group's Free Fire India Today League gaming tournament in 2019 saw over 125,000 participants from across India. The group's ESports Premier League using Free Fire was a first-ever franchisee format tournament, much like the IPL format in cricket, and saw over a million registrations.

ROOM FOR IMPROVEMENT

Despite the surging interest in gaming, many issues need to be addressed in this industry. One area that can be improved is the quality of the games being developed in India. Overseas developers pump in hundreds of crores of rupees into game development, making such games more endearing to gamers. "These are 'AAA' games, or games that have a high development and market budget of anywhere between Rs 100 crore and Rs 200 crore," says Vishwalok Nath, business head, gaming and esports, India Today Group, adding that it is akin to developing a big-budget movie and the graphics look quite realistic.

Moreover, the focus on gaming in India is in the services space rather than on creating proprietary products that command a higher value. Yet another challenge in India is dealing with the taboo around gaming. Most parents still view gaming as something that diverts their children's attention from studies. They fear it can have an adverse impact on their mental and physical health. Industry players feel this can be addressed by creating more awareness around gaming. "The inclusion of esports in the Asian Games adds a lot of legitimacy to this segment," says Aneesh Aravind, country manager, India, Krafton, a South Korean gaming company. Moreover, the fact that it can create employment for the youth is an added attraction. There are also several popular Indian gamers with a formidable number of followers on YouTube. Total Gaming, a YouTube channel operated by gamer Ajay (he prefers not to mention his surname), has over 30 million subscribers. Naman Mathur, better known by his pseudonym Mortal, has over 7 million followers on YouTube. The lack of good training facilities in gaming is another hindrance. Ojha says that there are very few colleges in India that teach any structured gaming courses at present. Moreover, there is a dearth of experts to conduct such courses, which calls for more foreign collaborations in this segment.

The taboo around gaming is slowly lifting in India. But for the country to tap its real potential, it would need to focus on improving collaborations with overseas companies that have gone way ahead in developing proprietary products. It also needs to nurture skills in this space and include specialised gaming courses in colleges. The setting up of the task force is a firm step in this regard. ■